



!!CAUSATION – FAMOUS QUOTES

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"Sociology... is a science which attempts the interpretive understanding of social action in order thereby to arrive at a causal explanation of its course and effects."

- Weber, M. (1978). *Economy and Society: An Outline of Interpretive Sociology*. (G. Roth & C. Wittich, Eds.). University of California Press. (Original work published 1921).

Weber's concept of *Verstehen* (interpretive understanding) was explicitly about grasping the causal significance of meaning — not just what happened, but *why actors thought it made sense* to do what they did.

Karl Marx — on the constrained causality of human action:

"Men make their own history, but they do not make it as they please; they do not make it under self-selected circumstances, but under circumstances existing already, given and transmitted from the past. The tradition of all dead generations weighs like a nightmare on the brains of the living."

Marxists.org

— Marx, K. (1852). *The Eighteenth Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte*, ch. 1.

This is arguably the founding statement of structure-agency causation — people *cause* things to happen, but only within conditions they didn't choose. Causes are real but always contextual and historically embedded.

And from the Preface to *A Contribution to the Critique of Political Economy* (1859), the classic formulation of social determination:

"It is not the consciousness of men that determines their being, but, on the contrary, their social being that determines their consciousness."

— Marx, K. (1859). *A Contribution to the Critique of Political Economy*, Preface.

Hannah Arendt — on the boundlessness and unpredictability of social causation:

"Action, though it may proceed from nowhere, so to speak, acts into a medium where every reaction becomes a chain reaction and where every process is the cause of new processes."

— Arendt, H. (1958). *The Human Condition*. University of Chicago Press.

And relatedly:

"The reason why we are never able to foretell with certainty the outcome and end of any action is simply that action has no end." [Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy](#)

— Arendt, H. (1958). *The Human Condition*. p. 233.

Arendt is making a deep point about why causal explanation in human affairs can never be fully predictive — because action enters into a *web of relationships* where causation ramifies without limit. She also argued that the "new always happens against the overwhelming odds of statistical laws and their probability" [Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy](#) — a direct challenge to probabilistic causal models.

Kurt Lewin — on behaviour as a function of person and environment: "Every psychological event depends upon the state of the person and at the same time on the environment, although their relative importance is different in different cases."

— Lewin, K. (1936). *Principles of Topological Psychology*. McGraw-Hill. p. 24.

His famous formula $\mathbf{B} = \mathbf{f}(\mathbf{P}, \mathbf{E})$ — behaviour is a function of the person and their environment — is essentially a causal claim that refuses to separate individual from context.

And on the relationship between understanding and intervention:

"If you want truly to understand something, try to change it." [A-Z Quotes](#)

— Widely attributed to Lewin (though the precise sourcing is disputed; see Tolman, 1996).

And of course:

"The research needed for social practice can best be characterized as research for social management or social engineering. It is a type of action research, a comparative research of the conditions and effects of various forms of social action, and research leading to social action. Research that produces nothing but books will not suffice." [Wikiquote](#)

— Lewin, K. (1946). Action research and minority problems. *Journal of Social Issues*, 2(4), 34–46. (Reproduced in Lewin, 1948, p. 202–3.)

Sigmund Freud — on psychic causation and the rejection of randomness in mental life:

"Nothing in the mind is arbitrary or undetermined."

This is Freud's principle of *psychic determinism*, articulated most fully in:

— Freud, S. (1901). *The Psychopathology of Everyday Life* (*Zur Psychopathologie des Alltagslebens*). (Standard Edition, Vol. 6.)

And from *The Interpretation of Dreams*:

"The dream is not meaningless, not absurd... it is a completely valid psychical phenomenon, actually a wish-fulfilment; it may be enrolled in the chain of intelligible psychical acts of the waking state; it has been built up by a highly complicated intellectual activity."

— Freud, S. (1900). *The Interpretation of Dreams*. (Standard Edition, Vols. 4–5.) ch. 3.

Freud's whole project was essentially a causal one: every symptom, slip, and dream has causes, but those causes are *meanings* — intentions, wishes, conflicts — not mechanical forces. A qualitative causal model if ever there was one.

Jürgen Habermas — on the relationship between causal explanation and understanding:

Habermas argued in *Knowledge and Human Interests* (1968) that the social sciences require a form of knowledge that integrates causal explanation with interpretive understanding, and that emancipatory knowledge involves recognising the *causal power of ideology* — how systematically distorted communication causes people to misrecognise their own interests.

"The self-reflection of a science... requires a going beyond this science into the reflection on the conditions of the possibility of knowledge and action."

— Habermas, J. (1968). *Knowledge and Human Interests* (*Erkenntnis und Interesse*). (Trans. J. Shapiro, 1971). Beacon Press.

He explicitly argued that the positivist separation of facts from values, and of causal explanation from interpretive understanding, was itself ideological.

On qualitative research and causal explanation

"Qualitative analysis, with its close-up look, can identify mechanisms, going beyond sheer association. It is unrelentingly local, and deals well with the complex network of events and processes in a situation."

— Miles, M. B. & Huberman, A. M. (1994). *Qualitative Data Analysis: An Expanded Sourcebook* (2nd ed.). Sage. p. 147.

"Adequate causal explanations in the social sciences depend on the in-depth understanding of meanings, contexts, and processes that qualitative research can provide." [ResearchGate](#)

— Maxwell, J. A. (2012). The importance of qualitative research for causal explanation in education. *Qualitative Inquiry*, 18(8), 655–661.

On realist/generative causation

"The task of science is the production of the knowledge of those enduring and continually active mechanisms of nature that produce the phenomena of the world." [Wikipedia](#)

— Bhaskar, R. (1975). *A Realist Theory of Science*. Leeds Books.

"Causal outcomes follow from mechanisms acting in contexts." [ResearchGate](#)

— Pawson, R. & Tilley, N. (1997). *Realistic Evaluation*. Sage. (ch. 3)

On the modus operandi approach

"Each cause has a set of footprints, a short one if it's a proximate cause, a long one if it's a remote cause, but in general the modus operandi is a sequence of intermediate or concurrent events or a set of conditions, or a chain of events, that has to be present when the cause is effective." [Better Evaluation](#)

— Scriven, M. (2008). A summative evaluation of RCT methodology: An alternative approach to causal research. *Journal of Multidisciplinary Evaluation*, 5(9), 11–24.

On reasons as causes

"People's motives or reasons for undertaking certain behaviors could not form part of general laws governing those behaviors, but ... those same motives or reasons could, in the individual case, cause the behaviors to be carried out."

— Mohr, L. B. (1996). *The Causes of Human Behavior: Implications for Theory and Method in the Social Sciences*. University of Michigan Press. p. vi.

"Agents are defined in terms of their tendencies and powers, among which in the case of human agents, are their reasons for acting." [ResearchGate](#)

— Bhaskar, R. (1979). *The Possibility of Naturalism*. Harvester Press. p. 118.

On qualitative/idiographic causal reasoning

"Idiographic causal explanations are bound within people's stories and interpretations. Usually, these are expressed through words." [Pressbooks](#)

— From *Foundations of Social Work Research* (open textbook), ch. 4.2 on Causality.

"Realism replaces the regularity model with one in which objects and social relations have causal powers which may or may not produce regularities, and which can be explained independently of them." [Springer](#)

— Sayer, A. (1992). *Method in Social Science: A Realist Approach* (2nd ed.). Routledge. pp. 2–3.

On evaluation and the "what works" question

The central realist evaluation question is not simply "does this intervention work?" but rather "what works, for whom, in what respects, to what extent, in what contexts, and how?" [Better Evaluation](#)

— Pawson, R. & Tilley, N. (1997). *Realistic Evaluation*. Sage.

On the fundamental task of social science

"The explanation of social phenomena by revealing the causal mechanisms which produce them is the fundamental task of research." [DOI](#)

— Danermark, B., Ekström, M., Jakobsen, L. & Karlsson, J. C. (2002). *Explaining Society: Critical Realism in the Social Sciences*. Routledge. p. 1.
